

UCLA Biostatistics Newsletter

Research, students, alumni, teaching, service, and community life from your Department of Biostatistics.

From the Chair

The life of a department extends beyond its classrooms, seminars, and research meetings. It is found in the ideas we develop, the students we mentor, the collaborations we build, and the paths our graduates follow after leaving UCLA. This quarterly newsletter is an effort to bring those parts of our community into closer conversation.

In these pages, I hope we will celebrate the work of our students, staff, faculty, and alumni, share the many ways biostatistics contributes to science and public health, revisit our department's history, and remain connected with the community that has grown around UCLA.

The newsletter will evolve with the community it represents. I welcome your ideas for articles, profiles, memories, accomplishments, and other topics you would like us to feature. I hope you will see this as your newsletter and help make it a lively reflection of who we are, where we have been, and where we are going.

Thank you for joining us along this path.

Michele Guindani

In this issue

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Early history of Biostatistics at UCLA

Professor Emeritus and Dean Emeritus Abdelmonem A. Afifi looks back at the people, decisions, and sense of community that shaped UCLA Biostatistics - from its beginnings as a small division in the new School of Public Health to the department we know today.

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Summer Internships and BSA Welcome

Students share practical advice from their experiences with summer internships across biotech, defense, technology, pharmaceuticals, and more, followed by a welcome letter from BSA leadership.

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A Summer of Visibility and Recognition

This summer brought many publications, major conference visibility, faculty honors, student recognition, and new opportunities to connect with alumni and collaborators.

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CAREER

Beyond the CV: Building a Professional Presence as a Biostatistician

Whether you are creating your first professional profile or updating an existing one, consider which tools serve your goals: websites, research profiles, computational portfolios, and build professional networks.

[Read more](#)

Stay connected. Explore department links at linktr.ee/uclabiostat.
Share alumni and friends updates at tiny.cc/uclabiostatfriends
See [selected fall events](#) on page 22.

FEATURE ARTICLE

Early history of Biostatistics at UCLA

By Professor Emeritus and Dean Emeritus Abdelmonem A. Afifi



I would like to thank Professor Michele Guindani for inviting me to contribute this article to the inaugural issue of the newsletter. I write from memory, and the account is as accurate as I can recall at the time of writing, with some historical details drawn from UCLA websites.

The beginnings of public health at UCLA

The University of California established a systemwide School of Public Health in 1943, headquartered at UC Berkeley. In 1946, UCLA began offering undergraduate public health instruction through its Department of Public Health, then part of the systemwide school. Dr. A. Harry Bliss was recruited to develop a curriculum and served as chair of the department from 1947 to 1956. UCLA awarded its first four BS degrees in public health in 1948.

In 1954, Dr. Wilton Halverson was named associate dean of the University of California's public health program at UCLA. Halverson appointed Drs. John Chapman, Wilfrid Dixon, and Lenor S. "Steve" Goerke to develop programs in epidemiology, biostatistics, and health administration, respectively. In 1957, UCLA began offering its first program leading to an advanced degree in public health.



Figure 1: Wilfrid Dixon, recruited to develop UCLA's program in biostatistics.



Figure 2: Lenor S. “Steve” Goerke speaking at a 1968 dedication ceremony.

The UCLA School of Public Health was established as an independent school by the University of California Regents on March 17, 1961, with headquarters in the Home Economics Building, now Campbell Hall. Dr. Goerke was named the school’s first dean.

The new school began with 57 full- and part-time faculty members, compared with 247 today, organized into seven divisions: Biostatistics, Epidemiology, Health Administration, Occupational Health, Health Education, Environmental Health, and Public Health Nutrition. It offered graduate programs leading to MS, MPH, PhD, and DrPH degrees, as well as an undergraduate BS degree. Total graduate and undergraduate enrollment was under 300, compared with more than 1,000 today.

“From the beginning, the Department’s curricula emphasized a balance between methodology and practice.”

Biostatistics takes shape

The Division of Biostatistics was the only entity on campus with the word statistics in its name. Some mathematical statisticians at UCLA held appointments in the Department of Mathematics, while other departments, including Education and Business Administration, also had statisticians—as they still do today.

The division offered five degrees: BS, MPH, MS, DrPH, and PhD. From the beginning, its curricula emphasized a balance between methodology and practice. The MS and PhD programs were more theoretical, while the other degrees were more applied. The same balance guided faculty hiring and promotion, as well as student recruitment.

Early faculty members included Wilfrid Dixon; Frank Massey, after whom the Biostatistics Library is named; Jean Mickey and her husband, Ray Mickey; and Olive Jean Dunn. Virginia A. Clark received the first PhD in Biostatistics and joined the division as an assistant professor after graduating in 1963. Professor Massey served as chair of the Department of Public Health and associate dean of the School of Public Health from 1966 to 1970. Professor Clark later served in the same roles from 1974 to 1982.

Professors Dixon and Massey wrote the widely used textbook *Introduction to Statistical Analysis*. Its first edition appeared in 1959 and its fourth and final edition in 1984. It was the first of several popular textbooks written by UCLA Biostatistics faculty members. Copies of most of these books can be seen in the Massey Library.



Figure 3: Olive Jean Dunn, an early Biostatistics faculty member and head of the division when Afifi arrived at UCLA.

“The Division of Biostatistics was the only entity on campus with the word statistics in its name.”

Joining the division

I joined the UCLA School of Public Health in September 1965 as an assistant professor of Biostatistics. I had received my PhD in Statistics from UC Berkeley in January 1965 and then served as a visiting assistant professor of Statistics at the University of Wisconsin–Madison from January to June of that year.

Professor Dunn was the division head. In addition to the UCLA Biostatistics faculty members mentioned above, Wally Blischke served as an adjunct professor, with his primary appointment in the USC School of Business. I was therefore the eighth faculty member in the division. By comparison, Biostatistics today has 35 full- and part-time faculty members. At the time, there were fewer than 30 Biostatistics students; in the 2025–26 academic year, there were 168.

A new home – and a strong community

Campbell Hall, the initial home of the School of Public Health, was a comfortable building with its own cafeteria. We occupied two floors, and faculty from across the school mingled freely. We soon outgrew the space, however. A new building was planned in the mid-1960s for the school’s current location, and we moved there in 1968.

The new building, with seven floors and two basements, felt more vertical than horizontal. People did not mingle as easily as they had in Campbell Hall. Still, there has always been a strong sense of community in the School of Public Health. In those early days, the school was small enough that Dean Goerke regularly hosted parties at his home and invited the entire faculty.

That spirit also permeated the Division of Biostatistics. We held an annual fall picnic at the UCLA Recreation Center, complete with grilled food and volleyball, for faculty, students, and staff. We also had an annual holiday party in December and other gatherings in faculty members’ homes. It was a lot of fun.



Figure 4: Virginia A. Clark, the first recipient of a PhD in Biostatistics at UCLA.

Growth, connections, and an idea ahead of its time

Professor Dixon and Dean Goerke disagreed about space for Dixon's Biomedical Computing Facility, which the new building was not large enough to house. Dixon accepted an offer from the School of Medicine to locate the facility there and established another department, Biomathematics, now the Department of Computational Medicine. He maintained an active joint appointment in the Division of Biostatistics, and several Biostatistics faculty members, including me, held joint appointments in Biomathematics.

During the 1970s and 1980s, new appointments in the division included David Hosmer; Potter Chang, who retired in the late 1990s; William Cumberland, department chair from 1996 to 2014 and emeritus since 2017; Martin Lee, who remains active; James Sayre; and David Gjertson. Lee, Sayre, and Gjertson earned their doctoral degrees from our division. Hosmer's wife was an Olympic-level cross-country skier, so after one year he moved to the University of Vermont, where she could train more easily.

In the late 1970s and early 1980s, Bill Cumberland, Jim Sayre, and I created an MS degree in Statistical Data Management that combined coursework in computer science, biostatistics, and public health. It was ahead of its time and, sadly, ended after a few years. In many ways, it was a forerunner of our successful Master of Data Science in Health program, launched at the right time in 2023.

"In many ways, this earlier master's program was a forerunner of our successful Master of Data Science in Health program."

From division to department

I served as dean of the School of Public Health from 1985 to 2000. Two major developments took place during those years.

At the time, the school had a single department containing several divisions, whose number varied over the years. As the school expanded and matured, it became clear that this arrangement was no longer tenable and that a structure with multiple departments was needed. I appointed a multidisciplinary committee to examine the options, and we settled on the current five-department structure. The reorganization was finalized in 1989 and has served the school well ever since.

Saving the School of Public Health

In June 1993, the UCLA administration proposed closing some professional schools and combining others. Under the plan, the School of Public Health would be disestablished. Biostatistics and Epidemiology would move to the School of Medicine; Community Health Sciences and Health Services Administration would move to a proposed School of Public Policy; and the future of Environmental Health Sciences remained undecided.

We were determined to fight the plan. The faculty and I selected the late Professor E. Richard “Rick” Brown of Community Health Sciences to lead the effort to save the school. I remained in the background to keep communication open with the administration, while also participating actively in the resistance.

Under Rick’s leadership—and with the help of several student and alumni leaders—we mounted a national campaign called “Save Our School,” or SOS. We received a tremendous outpouring of support from academic and practicing public health communities across the country. The campaign succeeded: in 1994, the UCLA administration decided to keep the School of Public Health intact.

A continuing legacy

By the time I stepped down as dean on July 1, 2000, both the Department of Biostatistics and the School of Public Health were ranked among the top 10 in the country by U.S. News & World Report. They remain there today, even as the number of schools of public health has risen from 24 to 67.

One final milestone came in 2012. On March 22, the UCLA School of Public Health was officially renamed the UCLA Jonathan and Karin Fielding School of Public Health. The change followed a landmark \$50 million gift from faculty member Dr. Jonathan Fielding and his wife, Karin, helping to ensure a bright future for the school.

Share ideas, celebrate successes

Two new portals are now available to help strengthen our department community.

Please use the [Initiatives and Suggestions portal](#) to propose new initiatives, structural improvements, and collaborations across the university.

Please use the [Community Recognition portal](#) to share publications, awards, student defenses, and other accomplishments that we should celebrate and announce.

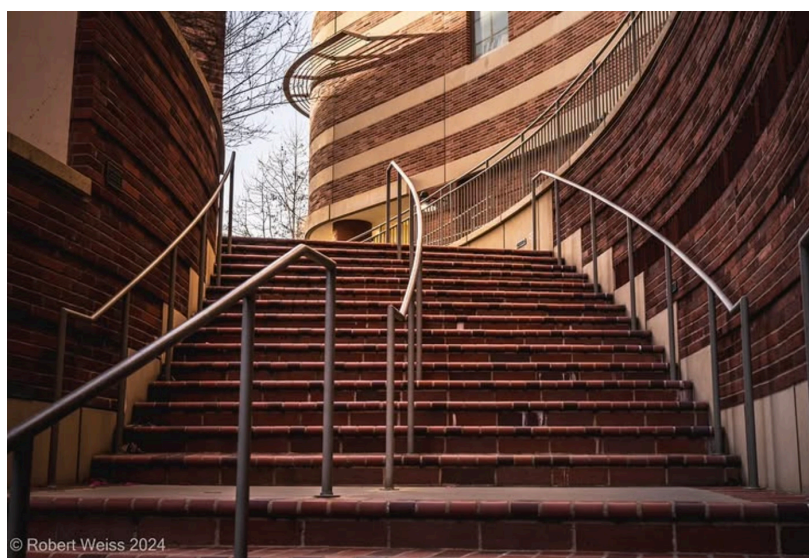


Figure 5: Courtesy of Prof. Rob Weiss, @robaucla on Instagram: “I don’t think our stairs on campus get their proper acknowledgements (except for the Janss steps). These are the stairs next to biological sciences.”

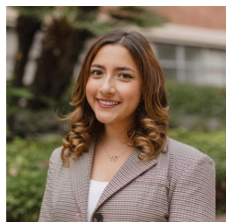
STUDENT EXPERIENCE

Biostatistics Summer Internships

Every summer, students in our department pursue summer internship opportunities across biotech, defense, technology, pharmaceuticals, and more! A panel of UCLA Biostatistics students share their experiences regarding internship search, application process, and reflections on experiences.

By **Cindy J. Pang**

The Panelists



Karen Harrison
MDSH
Centrillion Technologies



Julian Gavino
MS
Lockheed Martin



Siddhant Patel
MS
ASML



Darren Lin
PhD
AbbVie



Yanlong Bai
PhD
Genentech

How did you find your internship?

LinkedIn, Company Websites, getting referrals, leveraging alumni connections, and Handshake.

Walk us through your application timeline.

Patel: “I applied sometime between November through January ... [In] Total I spent 3-5 hours a week at most between browsing LinkedIn and applying.”

Bai: “I started my application from September or October and got the first interview in early February next year... I still recommend starting it [application] as early as possible. I spent about 2-3 hours/day to search for openings and have filled out over 100 application forms.”

Gavino: “I started in late September and got my offer in mid-April, but I would do a little bit of searching every day.”

Lin: “I applied sometime between November through January... I applied to a few internships over the course of a couple weeks.”

Harrison: “I started my summer internship search the beginning of January and was sending applications until May. My strategy was to stress the quality ... over quantity. I created a detailed recruitment spreadsheet. ... Over the course of 5 months, I applied to 103 positions, received 3 independent interviews, and one offer.”

What did you do to prepare for your interviews? Is there anything you wish you did differently?

Patel: “I leveraged my connections and my network’s connections, scheduled coffee chats with as many people as I could in the field most relevant to what I wanted to pursue. ... [If I did anything differently,] I would say start earlier.”

Bai: “1) Understand what titles or roles are relevant, and what knowledge or skillset they are looking for. Different tracks may have different requirements, e.g., data scientists/engineer track [is different from] biostatistics track. So make good use of AI tools for information gathering. 2) Optimize and refine your resume. If you want to apply for multiple roles, prepare role-specific resumes. 3) Practice for your interviews ... and be confident.”

Gavino: “I become a stronger storyteller during my interviews when talking about my experiences and wish I had a few more stories prepared beforehand.”

Lin: “For the interviews themselves, my LinkedIn and website helped visibility and giving the managers a sense of who I was before I met with them... I was ready to talk about my research interests and my goals. I was very honest about my intent with doing an internship, which was that I was still trying to figure out whether or not I wanted to do into academia or industry after graduation. ... I wish I had applied to more tech-heavy jobs (i.e., Google, Apple, etc.) and jobs in other fields.”

Harrison: “I watched data science YouTube videos to help prepare for AI and ML topics (StatQuest with Josh Starmer is a great creator). For each interview, I created Docs and took detailed notes on the company. I practiced recording myself and answering out-loud example interview questions that I would cater toward the specific position. I would then iterate by watching back the recording and retook it if I wanted my answer to sound more refined. ... One thing I’d do different is apply to more jobs so I could have more options ideally and interview practice.”

What surprised you most about the internship itself – whether about the work, culture, day-to-day rhythm, etc?

Patel: “To be honest, I thought my schedule would look like a typical 8-5... [but] I do my work, deliver my results, and network, but I’m also spending time playing pool with other interns and exploring the office campus.”

Bai: “The working pace in industry is pretty fast and compact. My calendar was generally filled up with meetings and my manager and collaborator usually expected to have some progress every week or every other week. ... Regarding career prospects, before this internship, I had heard that advanced degrees could play an important role in long-term career development in the pharmaceutical industry, but I did not have a clear sense of what that meant in practice. Through this experience, I gained a better understanding of the different career paths within the industry and saw that, particularly for more research-oriented or scientific leadership roles, having a PhD can be a valuable advantage and is quite common among people who advance in these areas.”

Gavino: “I was surprised about the amount of freedom I was given to complete my projects.”

Lin: “I was surprised by how organized AbbVie is. Everything is centralized and incredibly streamlined... through Microsoft Teams, it was incredibly easy to get in touch with other employees, set up meetings, book rooms, etc... The biggest surprise was the difference in what industry emphasized as important. Academia is very focused on cutting-edge research, with a strong emphasis on AI and more niche methods of statistics. In industry however, I learned that they place a very strong emphasis on popular interpretable models instead. ... Good presentations are king (i.e., Beamer is frowned upon and dense text-heavy

slides are discouraged)”

Harrison: “One of the most surprising parts of my internship experience is how independent you become, and confident you must be... I am there to learn and grow my own skillset, which can feel scary at times, but it is the best experience for growth.”

What is one piece of advice you’d give to a student who is just starting to think about internships?

Patel: “It’s a numbers game. Your resume needs to stand out, and what that looks like for everyone is different, but apply to anything and everything, if it’s moderately related to what you want long term. Pay doesn’t matter so much for an internship; it’s all about the experience and what you can speak to.”

Bai: “Think early, move early, and do NOT give up easily.”

Gavino: “Prioritize networking over applying online. For example, finding recruiters through campus events would be very helpful.”

Lin: “Do an internship early. It will help immensely with figuring out what you want to do after graduation. It also gives you a much wider perspective on how statistics is used broadly. For instance, I’ve learned what academia prioritizes is very different from what industry prioritizes. I’ve also learned a lot of skills and information that are hard to pick up on in the day-to-day of school (e.g. making good presentations, potential FDA policy changes, networking, how companies in pharma rank against each other, etc.). These things have actually given me some ideas on the direction to take my own research. It’s been great being able to step back a bit just to get some perspective on the field.”

Harrison: “Start. Early. I cannot emphasize this enough. If I were to go back and do it all over, I would start looking for internships throughout the entire school year, even the summer prior, just to send out applications early, and save dates when you know certain companies will be opening up their applications so you don’t miss the deadline. Even just dedicating 1 hour a week to recruitment starting in September will pay DIVIDENDS.”

If you have any questions for the students featured in this article, please feel free to email them or connect with them on LinkedIn!

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RESEARCH HIGHLIGHTS

Student Publication Highlights

Recent publications and preprints · Updated September 2026

Dissertation research

Kyle Lin Wu publishes two first-author papers

Kyle Lin Wu has published two first-author papers from his dissertation research with Professor Sudipto Banerjee. The papers address related challenges in spatial biostatistics: identifying meaningful health disparities between neighboring regions and understanding spatial confounding in multivariate disease analyses.

Assessing Spatial Disparities: A Bayesian Linear Regression Approach

Kyle Lin Wu and Sudipto Banerjee. *Biostatistics*.

DOI: [10.1093/biostatistics/kxaf048](https://doi.org/10.1093/biostatistics/kxaf048) | [arXiv: 2407.19171](https://arxiv.org/abs/2407.19171)

This paper develops a Bayesian linear regression framework for detecting sharp differences between neighboring geographic regions on disease maps. It uses posterior probabilities and Bayesian false discovery rate control to identify difference boundaries while retaining analytical tractability. The authors evaluate the method on maps of U.S. counties and apply it to county-level estimates of lung cancer mortality.

Spatial Confounding in Multivariate Areal Data Analysis

Kyle Lin Wu and Sudipto Banerjee. *Biometrics*, Volume 82, Issue 3, September 2026; published online August 11, 2026.

DOI: [10.1093/biomtc/ujag143](https://doi.org/10.1093/biomtc/ujag143) | [arXiv: 2505.07232](https://arxiv.org/abs/2505.07232)

This paper studies spatial confounding when several related outcomes are analyzed jointly. Using a Bayesian coregionalized areal regression model, the authors ex-

amine the issue from both analysis-model and data-generation perspectives. Their results show that multivariate spatial models can limit posterior variance inflation, need not add bias, and can improve precision over non-spatial alternatives, even when the spatial structure is misspecified.

Preprint

Filippo Monti leads new preprint

UCLA Biostatistics doctoral student Filippo Monti leads a new preprint with Andrew Holbrook, Nathan E. Glatt-Holtz, and Marc A. Suchard on efficient inference for multivariate Ornstein–Uhlenbeck processes.

Stable Matrix Parametrizations and Structured Adjoints for Ornstein–Uhlenbeck Processes

Filippo Monti, Andrew Holbrook, Nathan E. Glatt-Holtz, and Marc A. Suchard. *arXiv preprint*; submitted August 17, 2026.

DOI: [10.48550/arXiv.2608.16401](https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2608.16401) | [arXiv: 2608.16401](https://arxiv.org/abs/2608.16401)

The preprint develops a stable and computationally efficient parametrization for multivariate Ornstein–Uhlenbeck processes. Estimation is challenging because the drift matrix must remain Hurwitz stable, while likelihood and gradient calculations repeatedly require matrix exponentials and Lyapunov-equation solutions. The proposed parametrization represents the drift through stable one- and two-dimensional blocks, enforces stability through scalar constraints, and supports smooth transitions between real- and complex-eigenvalue regimes. Structured adjoints accelerate likelihood and derivative calculations, with applications to asynchronous financial data and multivariate phylogenetic traits.

Letter from **Biostatistics Student Association (BSA)** Leadership



Cindy J. Pang



Nena Ojukwu

Dear Biostatistics Community,

We are pleased to welcome new and returning members of our Biostatistics community this fall quarter. To our new students: welcome to UCLA — and if you're new to the city, welcome to Los Angeles!

We also want to take a moment to celebrate the commitment and energy that our community showed this past year. Thanks to the continued support of the Department of Biostatistics and the Master of Data Science in Health (MDSH) program, our Lunch and Learn series and Alumni Panel were both great successes. These events brought together students, faculty, and alumni in ways that strengthened our shared sense of community. We're proud of the momentum these events built, and we're looking forward to continuing them, along with new programming throughout this year.

None of this happens without the dedication of our student volunteers, and we're grateful to everyone who has given their time to plan events and support one another beyond the classroom. Behind the scenes, our board works closely with department faculty and staff to keep these traditions running smoothly, and we thank them for their continued guidance.

BSA is always looking for new members to help shape our events and community initiatives. If you're interested in getting involved, please reach out to any current board member. We are also recruiting for several open board positions this year (details to follow soon, so keep an eye out via your Student Affairs Officers (SAO) and BSA social media channels)

We welcome all members of our community to connect with us anytime — in person, by email, or through our BSA social media channels. We look forward to a great year together!

Warm regards,
Cindy J. Pang & Nena Ojukwu
BSA Co-Presidents

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**Follow BSA Socials to be in the know
about events, townhalls, and more!**



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COMMUNITY HIGHLIGHTS

A Summer of Visibility and Recognition

From ISBA in Nagoya to JSM in Boston, UCLA Biostatistics faculty, students, alumni, and programs were active across the statistical sciences community this summer.

Compiled by the newsletter editor

Conference

UCLA Biostatistics at JSM

The Department of Biostatistics had a strong presence at the 2026 Joint Statistical Meetings in Boston, with 22 affiliated presentations by students, faculty, and collaborators throughout the week. The breadth of the program reflected the department's active role across methodological, applied, and interdisciplinary areas of statistical science.

UCLA Biostatistics and UCLA Statistics & Data Science hosted a very well-attended joint reception at the Westin Boston Seaport. The event brought together current students, faculty, alumni, and friends of the two departments for a warm evening of conversation and reconnection.

Invited Lecture

Marc Suchard recognized by WNAR

Professor Marc Suchard delivered the Western North American Region 2026 Research Impact Award Lecture at JSM, "Inference for Discrete-Valued Stochastic Processes in Infectious Diseases." The lecture highlighted the impact of his work at the intersection of statistical methodology, computation, and infectious disease research.

Student Award Session

Emma Landry recognized at JSM

After defending her dissertation in spring 2026, Dr. Emma Landry presented her work on warped functional mixed membership models for EEG spectral features in one of the SBSS Student Paper Award sessions. Her presentation showcased innovative statistical modeling for complex neurological data.

Program Visibility

MDSH reaches a global audience

The Master of Data Science in Health program hosted a table at the ISBA World Meeting, creating an opportunity to introduce the program to an international audience of researchers, students, and collaborators interested in Bayesian statistics, data science, and health.



Figure 6: Dr. Emma Landry holding the SBSS Travel Award Certificate and her PhD advisor, Dr. Donatello Telesca.

International Meeting

UCLA Biostatistics at ISBA

Earlier in the summer, our community was also well represented at the ISBA World Meeting in Nagoya, Japan, the biennial flagship conference of the International Society for Bayesian Analysis. Faculty and students presented their work and contributed to a week of scientific exchange with the international Bayesian community.

Grant

Andrew Holbrook receives NIGMS MIRA R35

Professor Andrew Holbrook received an NIGMS Maximizing Investigators' Research Award for Early Stage Investigators, providing \$2.1 million in total funding for his research program, "Deep Bayesian Biostatistics: AI-Accelerated Inference for Big N and Big P." The award provides long-term, flexible support for an ambitious research program at the interface of Bayesian statistics and

artificial intelligence.

Recognition

Soumyakanti Pan honored

Dr. Soumyakanti Pan, a recent graduate of our doctoral program and now a postdoctoral fellow at the University

of Washington, received the Dean's Outstanding Student Award in Biostatistics and was recently featured by the UCLA Fielding School of Public Health. The main article from his dissertation, published in Bayesian Analysis under the guidance of Professor Sudipto Banerjee, was also selected as one of three journal highlight papers at the ISBA World Meeting.



Figure 7: UCLA Biostatistics students presenting their research and MDSH faculty connecting with attendees at the 2026 ISBA World Meeting in Nagoya, Japan.

Seminars

UCLA Biostatistics seminars: <https://tiny.cc/UCLAbiostatseminars>

UCLA Statistics seminars: <https://tiny.cc/UCLASestatseminars>

CAREER

Beyond the CV: Building a Professional Presence as a Biostatistician

Practical guidance on presenting your work, developing professional connections, and engaging responsibly online

As biostatisticians, we spend much of our training learning how to do careful work and communicate it through papers, presentations, and collaborative projects. These remain the foundations of a professional career. At the same time, our work is often spread across many places, and a CV alone does not always tell a potential collaborator, employer, student, or practitioner what problems we work on, what we contribute to a team, or where they can learn more about our work.

This is particularly true in biostatistics, where the nature of our contribution is not always apparent from a publication list. We may develop the methodology, design the study, guide the analysis, build the software, or help translate a scientific question into a statistical one. By describing our roles in specific projects and linking to the resulting papers, software, and other resources, a professional presence can help others understand the expertise we bring and identify opportunities to work with us. The goal is not to collect followers or engage in constant self-promotion. It is to make our work easier to find, understand, and evaluate, including the contributions that a publication list alone may not convey. The most useful professional presence usually has several connected components, each serving a different purpose.

A Personal Website

Among these tools, a personal website is probably the most important, both for established academics and for students beginning to build a professional profile. For academics, it brings together research, teaching, software, and collaborative work in one place. For students, it provides space to describe developing interests and share research and course projects, technical skills, posters, code, and other work that may not yet be reflected in a publication record. Students do not need an extensive CV before creating a website. A simple, accurate page can be useful when applying for internships, graduate programs, fellowships, or jobs, or when reaching out to potential mentors and collaborators. Compared with an institutional webpage, a personal website also offers more control over how this work is presented and can move with the individual as their career develops.

The website does not need an elaborate design or frequent posts. One well-maintained page can be enough if it includes:

1. Your full name, current program or position, and affiliation.
2. A short description of the statistical problems and scientific areas in which you are interested or work.
3. Selected research, course projects, publications, software, posters, or collaborative work, as appropriate to your career stage.
4. Information about teaching and mentoring, when relevant.
5. A current CV and contact information.
6. Links to your ORCID record, Google Scholar profile, LinkedIn page, and GitHub account, when appropriate.

As you put the page together, give some thought to how you describe your work. A clear, specific description is usually more useful to a visitor than an elaborate visual design. Broad labels such as “machine learning, artificial intelligence, and data science” may identify general areas of interest, but they say relatively little about the questions you want to address. A statement such as “I am interested in developing statistical methods to study how environmental exposures relate to health” gives readers a better starting point for understanding your interests.

You can then connect that description to a few examples of your work, with brief explanations of the questions involved, your contributions, and links to papers, posters, or code. For students, these examples can come from coursework or projects still in progress, and the interests described will naturally evolve. The aim is to help visitors understand what you work on, what experience you bring, and where they can learn more.

Once the website is in place, a little regular maintenance will help it remain useful. Changes in your position, degree program, or contact information are good occasions to update the page, refresh your CV, and add recent work.

Between these transitions, check occasionally that links still work and that project descriptions are current. An outdated affiliation or CV can leave visitors uncertain about where you are or what you are working on. Keeping the site manageable makes this upkeep easier: a simple page that you maintain consistently will usually serve you better than an elaborate site that becomes difficult to update.

Where Can You Build a Website for Free?

Several services offer free options for creating and hosting a professional website. Here are a few to consider:

Option	Best suited for	Technical level
GitHub Pages	A durable personal website connected to a computational portfolio	Basic
Quarto with GitHub Pages	Biostatistics students who use R, Python, Julia, or Jupyter	Intermediate
Google Sites	Students who want a simple website without writing code	None

GitHub Pages is probably the best general option. It provides free hosting through a public GitHub repository and creates an address of the form:

`https://username.github.io`

You can update the site through the GitHub website, so you do not need to know how to use Git from the command line to get started. The source files are public under the free plan, so you should never include confidential data, private correspondence, credentials, or unpublished collaborative material.

GitHub provides an official [GitHub Pages quick-start tutorial](#), as well as more detailed instructions on [creating a GitHub Pages site](#).

If you use R, Python, Julia, or Jupyter, you may prefer to create your website with [Quarto](#). Quarto allows you to maintain text, code, figures, publications, and project pages within the same reproducible framework. The official tutorials explain how to [create a Quarto website](#) and [publish it through GitHub Pages](#).

This approach requires more initial setup than a basic GitHub Pages site, but it is particularly useful if you already prepare projects, analyses, or teaching materials in Quarto or computational notebooks.

Finally, [Google Sites](#) is the simplest option if you prefer not to work with Markdown, HTML, or Git. You can assemble pages visually and embed Google documents, presentations, videos, and images directly.

Google's official tutorials explain [how to create a site](#) and [how to publish and share it](#).

If you use an institutional Google account, consider whether you will retain access after leaving the institution. When permitted, using a personal account makes it easier to maintain the site as your career develops.

Overall, I would recommend GitHub Pages or Quarto with GitHub Pages. Both allow you to build a professional website while developing skills in version control, documentation, and reproducible communication.

ORCID

Another useful part of a professional profile is an ORCID iD: a free, persistent identifier that connects you with your affiliations and research contributions. It helps distinguish your work from that of researchers with similar names and stays with you through changes in institution, location, or name. This provides some continuity when your work appears across different journals, repositories, and institutional systems. You do not need an extensive publication record to register. You can create an ORCID iD early in your career and build the record as your work develops. Once you have one, use it consistently in manuscript and grant submission systems. ORCID also recommends adding current and previous email addresses and reviewing the visibility settings for the information in your record. Keeping a personal email address associated with the account can help you maintain access when you leave an institution. Further guidance is available in ORCID's [introduction to the identifier and its uses](#).

The main value of ORCID is in helping others attribute work correctly and connect information that might otherwise remain scattered. It serves a practical purpose within your professional profile, rather than providing a measure of research quality or, by itself, proof of identity.

Google Scholar

A public Google Scholar profile gives readers a convenient way to find your publications and see how they have been cited over time. It complements a personal website by bringing this information together in a familiar format. Because Google Scholar relies on automated indexing and author matching, however, the record needs occasional attention. Check that the publications listed are yours, remove duplicates, and add missing work. Google's own guidance acknowledges that author matching is not always accurate and explains how to correct these issues ([Google Scholar Profiles](#)).

Citation counts can provide some context on how your work has circulated through the literature, but they require interpretation. They vary by field, time since publication, and database, and they do not establish whether a contribution is correct, original, or important. When presenting your work, it is therefore more useful to explain the questions you addressed and what you contributed, allowing citation counts to serve as supporting information. This approach is consistent with the broader principle that quantitative indicators should support an informed assessment of research rather than determine it ([Hicks et al., 2015](#)).

“A professional presence helps others find your work, understand your contributions, and identify opportunities to work with you.”

LinkedIn

LinkedIn can help you maintain professional connections and make your experience visible to people across academia, health care, government, and industry. Its usefulness will naturally change as your career develops.

If you are beginning your career, you can use it to explore how biostatistical training translates into different kinds of work and identify alumni or other professionals whose experience interests you. Your own profile can describe your training, projects, technical skills, internships, and current interests, giving others a sense of what you have done and what you would like to pursue.

As you move into new roles, LinkedIn can help you keep in touch with former classmates, colleagues, mentors, and your department while making your current expertise easier to find. These connections also offer ways to support others: sharing an internship or job opening, offering career advice, recruiting, or making yourself available as a mentor. Describing your own career path can help those entering the field understand the range of opportunities available to biostatisticians.

If your work includes teaching or mentoring, LinkedIn can also help you follow the careers of former trainees and stay connected with alumni. It provides another way to share professional opportunities and communicate your expertise to potential collaborators beyond your immediate academic field.

Whatever your career stage, a useful profile should help a visitor answer three questions:

1. What do you do?
2. What methods and scientific areas do you have experience with?
3. Where can someone find examples of your work?

Specific descriptions make these questions easier to answer. A headline such as “Biostatistician working on causal inference and pragmatic clinical trials” gives readers more information than “data enthusiast.” For individual projects, briefly explain the problem, your role, and the outcome, while respecting any confidentiality restrictions. Links to your personal website, GitHub account, or other resources can then give interested readers a way to learn more.

Maintaining the profile is only part of the process; staying in touch and exchanging useful information also matter. A study using a representative Dutch panel found associations among networking, connections with more distant professional contacts, LinkedIn use, and access to professional information. These findings suggest a role for LinkedIn in maintaining a broader professional network, although they do not establish that using the platform itself causes career advancement ([Utz and Breuer, 2019](#)).

GitHub: Presenting Your Computational Work

If your work includes software or computational analysis, GitHub can provide concrete examples of how you approach a statistical problem. A well-documented project allows others to follow your reasoning, see how you organize and test code, and understand your contributions to collaborative work. This gives a potential employer or collaborator

a fuller picture of your experience than a list of programming languages alone.

You can begin with a few projects that reflect your interests and that you have taken the time to explain clearly. These might include an analysis, a simulation study, a software package, or a contribution to a collaborative project. GitHub's career guidance recommends highlighting three to five relevant repositories by pinning them to your profile, where visitors can find them easily ([GitHub profile guidance](#)).

For each project you choose to highlight, aim to explain:

1. The scientific or statistical question being addressed.
2. The methods used and your particular contribution.
3. Where the data come from and how they may be accessed or used.
4. How to install the required software and run the analysis.
5. The expected outputs, with an example where helpful.
6. Who contributed to the work and in what capacity.
7. The terms for reusing the code and the preferred citation.

The README is a good place to introduce this information. Think of it as a short guide for someone encountering the project for the first time: it should explain the purpose of the work, help the reader get started, and point to further documentation or help where needed ([GitHub README guidance](#)).

If you intend others to reuse your software, include a license that explains the permitted uses. Making a repository public does not, by itself, grant unrestricted permission to reuse its contents ([GitHub licensing guidance](#)). You can also add a [CITATION.cff](#) file to specify how the work should be cited. For a release associated with a paper or other research output, [archiving it through Zenodo](#) provides a persistent DOI and preserves the version being referenced.

“For an analysis to be reproducible, others need the code and enough information to run it and obtain the reported results.”

For an analysis repository, consider what someone would need to reproduce the reported results. Alongside the code, this includes information about the input data, software versions, parameter settings, random seeds where relevant, and the sequence of steps leading to the final tables or figures. Recording these details also makes it easier for you to return to your own work later. Sandve et al. provide useful guidance on developing these habits as part of everyday computational research ([Sandve et al., 2013](#)).

This approach can be particularly helpful early in your career, when a publication record may capture only a small part of what you can do. A carefully explained project gives you space to demonstrate statistical reasoning, justify decisions, and communicate findings. These are central themes in Nolan and Stoudt's discussion of portfolios as a way to make technical skills, reasoning, and professional development visible ([Nolan and Stoudt, 2021](#)).

Social Media: Sharing Research and Building Connections

Social media can complement the other parts of your professional presence, but participation is a matter of personal preference. A current website, accurate scholarly profiles, and well-documented work already provide a useful foundation. If you choose to participate, it helps to have a clear sense of what you want from it: keeping up with a methodological community, exchanging ideas, sharing resources, or helping interested readers find your work.

Research on social-media dissemination offers some support for these uses, although the findings depend on what is being measured. A 2024 systematic review included 50 studies, nine of which were randomized trials. It found evidence of increased article views, clicks, and downloads, as well as a positive pooled effect on citations. The studies varied considerably in quality, design, and the intensity of promotion, and evidence for changes in professional thinking or practice was less certain ([Roberts-Lewis et al., 2024](#)).

In a separate randomized experiment involving 110 promoted papers and 440 controls from 11 life-science journals, promotion increased short-term downloads and online attention, but the difference in citations after three years was not statistically significant. This does not rule out a modest citation effect, but it illustrates why greater visibility should not automatically be interpreted as greater scholarly impact ([Branch et al., 2024](#)).

For your own use, I would focus on helping people discover useful work and creating opportunities for discussion. A manageable approach might include:

1. Following journals, research groups, professional societies, public-health agencies, and methodological communities

relevant to your interests.

2. Sharing a brief explanation of a paper, software release, teaching resource, or statistical issue, together with a stable link.
3. Joining discussions by asking questions, offering a methodological perspective, or pointing to a useful resource.
4. Drawing attention to work by colleagues, trainees, and collaborators.
5. Choosing one or two communities where you find useful exchanges and can participate comfortably.

Some of the value may come from learning alongside others. A qualitative study based on interviews with 26 participants in the [#TidyTuesday](#) data-science community described opportunities to develop skills, build portfolios, and establish professional connections. It also identified difficulties for newcomers, including uncertainty about how to begin and limited access to constructive feedback ([Shrestha, Barik, and Parnin, 2021](#)).

When deciding where to spend your time, consider whether a community gives you opportunities to ask questions, learn from others' approaches, and contribute something useful yourself. Those exchanges can make participation worthwhile even if you post infrequently or have a small audience.

Explaining Your Work to a Broader Audience

As biostatisticians, we are accustomed to describing our work through the models and methods we develop or use. That language is useful among specialists, but visitors to a website or professional profile may need some context before the method's name means much to them. Beginning with the scientific question helps readers understand why the statistical problem matters and what your contribution offers.

A useful starting point is a short description organized around five questions, often with one sentence for each:

1. Problem: What scientific question or feature of the data makes the analysis challenging?
2. Gap: What do existing approaches overlook, or what assumptions may be unsuitable?
3. Contribution: What does your approach add or change?
4. Evidence: What have you established through theory, simulations, or applications, and under what conditions?
5. Further information: Where can someone find the paper, code, or a worked example?

For a project involving longitudinal data, an illustrative description might read:

Health studies often collect measurements at irregular intervals, and some participants stop attending visits as their health changes. Analyses can be biased if this dropout depends on outcomes that were not observed. We developed a joint model for health outcomes and dropout that allows individual health trajectories to vary flexibly. Simulations assess bias and interval coverage, while a clinical application illustrates how accounting for dropout affects the analysis. The paper and code are available at [\[link\]](#).

The level of detail can then be adjusted to the audience. Technical terms remain useful when they add precision, especially once readers understand the problem they describe. Experimental research has found that jargon can make scientific information harder to process and reduce engagement, even when definitions are provided. Giving readers a clear starting point can therefore help them engage with the technical explanation that follows ([Shulman et al., 2020](#)).

“A presentation can begin a conversation that continues long after the conference has ended.”

Making the Most of Conferences

Conferences provide opportunities to discuss your work with people who approach related questions from different perspectives. A presentation or poster can lead to useful feedback, introduce you to methods you had not considered, and begin conversations that continue after the meeting.

Research offers some evidence of these longer-term benefits. Using the cancellation of the 2012 American Political Science Association meeting as a natural experiment, de Leon and McQuillin estimated that presenting a paper increased its probability of receiving a citation within four years by approximately five percentage points ([de Leon and McQuillin, 2020](#)). A study of Gordon Research Conferences also found evidence that bringing researchers together supported subsequent collaboration, with greater benefits for junior researchers ([Chai and Freeman, 2019](#)). These findings concern particular conference settings, but they suggest that the exchanges surrounding a meeting can have value well beyond the presentation itself.

A little preparation can make those exchanges easier. Before the meeting, identify a few talks you would like to

attend and people whose work connects with your interests. Prepare a brief description of your own work, along with a longer explanation if the conversation develops. Leaving some room in your schedule for poster sessions and informal discussions can also be useful.

Afterward, a short, specific message is often enough to continue a conversation. Mention what you discussed and, when appropriate, include the paper, code, or resource you offered to share. If you post about the meeting, follow its policies and the presenter's preferences, and obtain permission before sharing slides, photographs, unpublished findings, or details from private conversations.

Visibility and Fair Recognition

As we encourage people to make their work easier to find, we should also recognize that opportunities for visibility are uneven. The researchers who are most prominent online do not necessarily represent the full range of expertise or contributions within a field. A study of scientists on Twitter, for example, found substantial differences across disciplines in representation and patterns of connection ([Ke et al., 2017](#)).

Other research points to barriers within professional networks themselves. In a United States LinkedIn field experiment using fictitious profiles of young men, connection requests from profiles depicting Black men were less likely to be accepted than otherwise comparable requests from profiles depicting White men ([Evsyukova, Rusche, and Mill, 2025](#)). An observational study of 23 million posts about 2.8 million papers found that women were less likely than men to promote their own publications, including among researchers who were active on the platform ([Peng et al., 2025](#)). These studies concern particular platforms and periods, but they show why online attention needs to be understood in the context of access, networks, and patterns of participation.

“Public engagement should remain a choice. Online activity should not become a measure of professional commitment or value.”

This also gives departments and professional communities a role to play. Keeping directories current, making introductions, circulating opportunities, and featuring colleagues' work through institutional channels can help recognition reach people who may have less time or inclination to promote their own work. Giving appropriate credit for software, study design, analysis, and other collaborative contributions is part of the same responsibility. These efforts should accompany mentoring, sponsorship, and fair hiring practices.

Public engagement should remain a choice. Your professional aims, available time, privacy concerns, and preferred ways of communicating may differ from those of your colleagues. A current website and a few accurate profiles can be sufficient. The extent of someone's online activity should not become an expectation against which their commitment or professional value is judged.

Sharing Work Responsibly

Making your work accessible also requires care about what can appropriately be shared. In biostatistics, our projects often involve obligations to research participants, collaborators, institutions, and employers. Public pages, repositories, and posts should exclude confidential participant information, restricted data, credentials, and proprietary material. Collaborative work should be shared only when it has been approved for release.

Before posting, check the agreements and policies relevant to the project, including any restrictions on data use, disclosure of results, authorship, or conference materials. Once information is public, deleting the original does not necessarily remove copies or downloads. When the original data cannot be shared, a clearly labeled simulated example may still help others understand the methods or software.

The [American Statistical Association's Ethical Guidelines for Statistical Practice](#) provide a useful reference for these decisions, including responsibilities concerning confidentiality, attribution, transparency, and the communication of limitations.

Bringing It Together

A useful professional presence gives others a clear and accurate picture of your work and makes it easier to connect with you. The tools discussed here serve different purposes, and their relevance will depend on your interests, career stage, and professional goals. You do not need to use all of them. The following can help you review what you already have in place and decide what would be useful to add or update:

1. Create or update your ORCID record, including your affiliations and contact information.
2. Maintain a personal website or institutional page that clearly describes your interests, work, and contributions.
3. Check your Google Scholar profile for accuracy if you have scholarly publications.
4. Keep your LinkedIn profile current if it supports your professional connections or career goals.
5. If computational work is part of your profile, highlight a few carefully documented GitHub projects; three to five is a useful target as your portfolio grows.
6. Prepare a short explanation of your current work that someone outside your immediate specialty can understand.
7. If you choose to use social media, focus on a community where you find useful discussions and opportunities to contribute.
8. Review your pages and profiles twice a year, updating affiliations and contact details whenever they change.

The research, teaching, software, and collaborative work behind these profiles remain the foundation of your professional life. Giving that work a clear and accessible home helps others understand what you contribute and where your interests might connect with theirs. A modest set of resources that you can maintain comfortably can serve this purpose well, with room to evolve as your career develops.

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DEPARTMENT GUIDE

Department of Biostatistics at a Glance

A practical reference to stay connected with UCLA Biostatistics.

UCLA Fielding School of Public Health

Leadership Department leadership

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Professor of Biostatistics
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Catherine M. Crespi, PhD
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Programs Degree programs

The department offers training in biostatistics and health data science through graduate programs that combine statistical methods, computation, data science, and public health applications.

- MS in Biostatistics
- PhD in Biostatistics
- Master of Data Science in Health (MDSH)

Department General contact

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UCLA Fielding School of Public Health
Box 177220, Suite 51-254 CHS
Los Angeles, CA 90095-1772

Email
biostat@ucla.edu
[Biostatistics Website](#)

Phone
Student-related inquiries: 310.267.2186
MDSH program inquiries: 310.206.8097
Department inquiries: 424.259.5180

MDSH Master of Data Science in Health

For MDSH questions, students and prospective students should first review the program FAQ. If the question remains unresolved, contact the MDSH team directly.

Program links
Website: mdsh.ucla.edu
FAQ: mdsh.ucla.edu
General inquiries: mdsh@ucla.edu

MDSH contacts

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Students Student support

For enrollment questions, degree requirements, forms, deadlines, and departmental procedures, students should contact the appropriate student affairs staff member.

Biostatistics students
Roxy Naranjo
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310.267.2186

MDSH students
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celdridge@ph.ucla.edu

Students Biostatistics Student Association

The Biostatistics Student Association (BSA) promotes academic growth, professional development, networking, and social connection among UCLA Biostatistics students.

Student contacts
Cindy Pang, co-President
cindypang@g.ucla.edu
Nena Ojukwu, co-President
ojukwun@g.ucla.edu

Website and membership
ucla-bsa.github.io
Join BSA / Interest Form

Community Share news, ideas, and updates

Initiatives and Suggestions
tiny.cc/uclabiostatsideas

Community Recognition
tiny.cc/uclabiostatsproud

Alumni and friends
tiny.cc/uclabiostatfriends

For items to be considered for school-wide newsletters, social media, or web features, please use the [MarComm Request & Submission Form](#):
<http://tiny.cc/UCLAFieldingMarketing>.

Department links
linktr.ee/uclabiostat

UCLA Fielding newsletters

Subscribe to [Fielding Notes](#) or the digital version of the [school magazine](#).

UCLA

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Selected Fall 2026 Events

Please watch department email and Slack announcements for updates.

Sept. 22	FSPH New Student Orientation, Biostatistics session CHS 51-279, 1:00–3:00 PM
Sept. 25	MDSH Orientation, Faculty Introductions CHS 73-105, 11:40 AM–12:10 PM
Sept. 30	Biostat Seminar: Amy Braverman JPL, Pasadena
Oct. 14	Biostat Seminar: Dani Gamerman Universidade Federal do Rio de Janeiro
Oct. 21	Biostat Seminar: Sebastien Haneuse UC Irvine
Oct. 28	Biostat Seminar: Tracy Ke Harvard
Nov. 9	MDSH Special Seminar: Therese Suarez Fox Corporation. Open to all students. 10:00–11:00 AM talk; 11:00 AM–12:00 PM town hall
Nov. 18	Biostat Seminar: Jeffrey Chiang UCLA Computational Medicine
Dec. 2	Biostat Seminar: Filippo Monti Current Biostatistics PhD student
Dec. 4	Department Holiday Gathering 12:00 PM, off-site venue; location to be confirmed